

Diem Assassinated

As 1963 dawned, the situation in South Vietnam was rapidly worsening, and it was not helped by the ARVN's performance near Ap Bac. As popular discontent with Diem and his despotic regime mounted, his generals began plotting his overthrow.

◀◀ BEFORE

Diem was on shaky ground, but had survived two previous attempts to overthrow him.

HOLDING ON BY A THREAD

Diem's **Strategic Hamlets Program**, intended to win him support, alienated the rural population. Meanwhile, the **Buddhist crisis** had led to protests on the streets and the public martyrdom of a Buddhist monk.

In November 1960, Lieutenant Colonel Vuong Van Dong led an **attempted military coup** but failed to overthrow the president. In February 1962, a second attempt was made: Diem and his family just managed to escape death when two renegade air force fighter pilots bombed and strafed the presidential palace.

As 1962 drew to a close, the opinion in both Saigon and Washington was that US military aid to South Vietnam was starting to tip the scales against the Viet Cong. What the US military advisers wanted was a chance to demonstrate how the ARVN, with US weaponry, could defeat the guerrillas. On January 1, 1963, they got their chance.

Fiasco at Ap Bac

During the previous week, South Vietnamese intelligence had reported that three companies of Viet Cong—plus local auxiliaries—were concentrating near Ap Bac, a village in the Mekong Delta. Lieutenant Colonel John Paul Vann, the top US adviser with the ARVN Seventh Division, urged its commander Colonel Bui Dinh Dam to attack. The idea was to launch a three-pronged pincer attack. One infantry regiment, landed by helicopters, would move in from the north. Two battalions of troops would advance from the south, and a rifle squadron on board armored personnel carriers would approach from the west. The ARVN had plenty of artillery and air support.

On the face of it, the Viet Cong looked doomed. The reality was different. In the first place, despite Vann's urgings, Dam delayed the attack for a crucial 24 hours. This gave the Viet Cong time to dig in behind prepared defenses. They patiently waited until the first three waves of helicopters had dropped troops, then, as the fourth wave came in to land, opened fire. The result was carnage. By noon, five US helicopters had been forced down and their crews were in danger. It took Vann three hours to persuade the South Vietnamese to make a rescue attempt. When he did, the vehicles advanced so slowly that they became sitting ducks.

Elsewhere, things were also going badly. The two battalions supposed to advance from the south refused to move forward. In addition, the South Vietnamese deployed the paratroopers Vann had proposed to block a Viet Cong retreat—but deployed them to the west, not in the east as Vann had requested. In the deepening twilight, they were mistaken for Viet Cong by their own side. In the confusion, the Viet Cong simply slipped away.

■ 6 The number of factions plotting to kill Diem during the lead-up to his assassination.

Crisis point